



Ubuntu 9.10—The Koala screams for attention

The Koala may have been the most publicised and talked about release of this month, something like the Linux 2.0 (a la the Web 2.0) for home users, aiming for a level of polish in its user interface hitherto unseen in the world of GNU/Linux. Apart from features like KMS and GRUB2, Mark Shuttleworth had considered ditching the yellow-brown colour palette for something new. Changes like ditching Pidgin for Empathy, which were rather radical at the time of the announcement, dismayed many Ubuntu fans.

Yet, Ubuntu has made it big. The user interface, though a bit loud in its shade of lemon yellow, is laudable

(see Figure 1). It's the same old GNOME though, and at version 2.28, a bit cleaner than the previous releases. In fact, I don't know if it's just me or it's the Ubuntu customisations, but I did stumble a bit after the first boot into GNOME 2.28.

Continuing about the downside of Ubuntu 9.10, KMS and GRUB2 also came as big disappointments to me. Since I have an Nvidia GeForce card, KMS didn't work at all (and sample this, an interview on Phoronix says that Nvidia has no immediate plans to introduce KMS support into their drivers) and that, along with GRUB2, made for a very unpleasant boot indeed. It seems that the developers put so much effort into developing the KMS experience that they neglected the non-KMS sector. And considering that KMS is fully supported only on Intel chipsets, and a lion's share of users use Nvidia and ATI cards, that's a very bad decision indeed. Even Fedora was better than this.

Now for the good things... Empathy. Pidgin, heralded as the irreplaceable chat client in the world of both Linux and Windows, has finally met its match, and it seems our little bird flew away to the Empathetic competition. Empathy has come a long way since its introduction and is now a pleasure to use—and it's certainly better than Pidgin, considering its support for rich chat features like voice and video.

The next unique offering is the Ubuntu Software Centre (Figure 3). Rather than use Synaptic by default for package management, it's hidden away for the advanced users. For the layman, the Ubuntu Software Centre acts rather like an app store (except that there's only free software here). Once you open it up, there's a screen with lots of sections. Let's say you want to install AmaroK, which you know is an audio player. So you click on *Sound And Video*. From the listing, select AmaroK. An arrow will appear in the selection, on the right side. Click on it. A mini-review of the software will appear, briefly describing it, along with a screenshot. Below it, there's a button. Click on it to install. Simple, isn't it?

Ubuntu also holds the distinction of being the first distribution to pay attention to those finer details that differentiate the polish of, say, Mac OS X and Windows to the crudeness of Linux. Packing in more smooth transition effects, extra wallpapers, visual styles and fonts than ever, users are now spoilt for choice (but weren't we before?) over how to make their system look. Coming to looks, Ubuntu has now adopted the Dust colour scheme in the Human theme, with Dark Chocolate Brown window borders and selections, and off-white panels and bars with a slight chocolate hue. Nice colour palette, but I'd rather stick with the Dust theme. There's a new icon scheme as well, called Humanity, but I don't know if it's just with me but many icons don't appear in the Places menu and none in the Systems menu. Apart from this, Humanity is another revolutionary icon theme with mind-blowing icons. Overall, it's a pleasure to actually work in this distro.